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Power: From Parity to Asymmetry

The differences between India and China on their mutual perceptions and worldviews, their perimeters, and their strategic partners might not matter if the power balance between them was more symmetric. In fact, the power gap between the two countries has grown relentlessly since about 1990. The consequence of this power gap is that China, given its superior position, is often assertive and insensitive towards India, and India, conscious of the gap, is increasingly desperate to be recognized as an equal and determined to stand firm in the face of Chinese challenges. Neither country is disposed to be accommodative. From a position of strength, China does not see the need to accommodate, while from a position of weakness, India feels it cannot afford to do so and risk further loss of standing and strategic autonomy.

Measuring a power gap is complicated. Fortunately, social scientists have given us some leads on the components and measures of power that allow us to make an estimate of the India–China gap. The Harvard political scientist Joseph S. Nye famously distinguishes between hard power and soft power. Hard power is the ability to get others to do what you want by force or coercion, usually through economic and military means; soft power is the ability to get others to do what you want by means of persuasion, usually by means of playing on their attraction to or regard for one's values, institutions, and achievements.[1] Based on these distinctions, India's and China's power balance is asymmetric, but with some surprises. From a relatively symmetric position in 1949, the power equation has shifted